attempt to challenge and transform the status quo. Sir Sorabji Pochkhanawala's unwillingness to endorse received wisdom made him a trailblazer. A sharp intellect, high ambition, and great courage all went into the founding of the Central Bank of India, set up by Indians and more importantly managed by them too. As N.J. Nanporia his biographer notes, 'There was in Sorabji, as there was in several other nineteenth century and early twentieth century Parsi pioneers including Jamsetji Tata a dash of the enlightened buccaneer. They would not otherwise have founded or pioneered anything.'[3] He adds, 'Central Bank was therefore not merely an enterprise crowned by commercial success but the materialization of the dream of a visionary, who also had his two feet firmly on the ground.'[4]

Sorabji was born on August 9, 1881, in Bombay, the youngest of four sons and three daughters of Goolbai and Nusserwanji Pochkhanawala. Sorabji's father died when Sorabji was only six years old. He was the proprietor of a hotel in Mazgaon called Hope Hall, also known as the Mazgaon Hotel. It was one of the better hotels of Bombay at the time and was patronized by Englishmen and visiting foreigners. He also owned Wellington Hotel on the Esplanade Road.[5] There is an appropriate irony in the circumstances that preceded Nusserwanji's death. Nusserwanji had deposited his wealth in a bank, which went into liquidation leaving the family in straitened circumstances. Sorabji learnt to fend for himself from very early on, and his capacity for initiative and innovation must have had as their mainspring this 'sense of having to think and act on the basis of his own personal resources.'[6] About a year after his father's demise tragedy struck once again when Rustumji, one of his brothers, was drowned in a well. Sorabji was the first to know about this sad accident. Returning home from school one day he found a large crowd near his home and pushing his way through the crowd discovered that his brother had drowned. It fell to Sorabji to convey these sad tidings to his family

Sorabji's elder brother Hirjibhoy who was employed on a monthly salary of ₹100 with the Chartered Bank of India, Australia and China took over the role of *pater familias*. He made many sacrifices for the sake of his family including refusing to marry the woman he loved to enable him to support the family. Known as Hirjibhoy Marker, he earned some extra money for the family by working as a billiards marker. He also had a love of music and gardening both of which he passed on to his younger brother.